Speaker 1

From Gimlet, this is reply All.

I'm Alex Goldman.

0:08

Speaker 2

And I’m PJ Vogt.

0:13

Speaker 1

PJ

Speaker 2

Yes.

Speaker 1

So about seven months ago, the end of January, I had just spent a long afternoon recording with producer Damiano Marchetti, and just during a break I got a phone call from a 1800 number.

0:28

And I don't know what it is about 1800 numbers.

My natural impulse is to just be curious as to who's calling me, so I always pick them up.

0:35

Speaker 2

Really?!

0:36

Speaker 1

Always.

0:38

Speaker 2

Do you have a natural impulse to open junk mail?

0:42

Speaker 1

If the subject's funny enough.

0:44

Speaker 2

OK.

0:45

Speaker 1

So I get this call.

It is a robot saying your iCloud may be compromised.

0:52

Speaker 3

We seriously recommend you to call us on 18448850011.

We request you not to use your computer or other Mac devices before speaking to our certified technicians.

1:04

Speaker 2

OK.

Speaker 1

And so I'm thinking to myself, I don't think my iCloud is compromised.

Yeah.

So I called them back.

1:12

Speaker 3

Your call is very important to us.

Please stay on the line and you'll be transferred to the next available agent.

Thank you for calling online support. You're talking to Alex.

How can I help you?

1:25

Speaker 1

What a coincidence.

My name is Alex.

I got a call that said that there was some...

1:29

Speaker 3

No your name is Michael Goldman.

1:32

Speaker 1

My middle name is Alex.

I go by Alex.

1:35

Speaker 3

Oh, you go by Alex.

OK Alex, how can I help you?

1:38

Speaker 1

Yeah, I got a call that.

So there was some suspicious activity going on in my iCloud.

1:44

Speaker 3

OK, what kind of activity?

How do you know about that?

1:47

Speaker 1

I got a call from you guys you.

1:48

Speaker 3

Got a call?

1:49

Speaker 1

Yeah.

1:50

Speaker 3

All right, Alex, we have seen that your IP address has been compromised from other countries in the last two days.

Have you been to some other countries using your devices over there?

2:00

Speaker 1

No.

2:03

Speaker 3

And did you have any computer like a laptop or desktop with you?

2:06

Speaker 1

Yes, I do.

2:09

Speaker 3

Alex, The thing is that we need the help of a computer so we can rectify this kind of issues.

Is that possible?

You can access the computer please?

2:16

Speaker 1

Yeah, I'm standing right in.

I'm sitting right in front of it.

Just to be clear, you guys from Apple?

2:22

Speaker 3

Yes, I'm a certified technician to support Apple.

That's right.

2:25

Speaker 1

OK.

Do you have some kind of ID, that ID number that I can call Apple to cross reference?

Because I don't.

I mean, I've never experienced anything like this before.

2:35

Speaker 3

Sir, you're already calling us, so you will call us back to refer my ID number.

2:41

Speaker 1

Yeah, well, I'm trying to figure out what's going on here and I just, I don't, you know, I'm, I'm curious what's going on.

2:51

Speaker 3

So you want to call one of my technician here to verify my IP address, my ID right?

2:56

Speaker 1

No, no, no, no, no no.

I want to call Apple to verify.

3:02

Speaker 3

You're already calling us, Sir, so you want to hang up the call and call us again?

3:06

Speaker 1

No, How do I know that you guys are Apple though?

What proof do I have?

I'm looking up this phone number.

I don't see it associated with Apple at all.

3:15

Speaker 3

You can look that again, Sir.

3:17

Speaker 1

I'm looking up this phone number online.

It does not say that it is any it's related to Apple in any way.

So I'm trying to figure out who you are.

Who are you?

Are you calling from Apple?

3:30

Speaker 3

We are Anonymous.

We are Legion.

Expect us.

3:37

Speaker 1

You're oh, you're Anonymous.

You're Legion.

Expect you?

Speaker 3

Yeah.

Speaker 1

Are you coming?

Are you coming for me?

3:44

Speaker 3

We'll be demolishing all your social identities.

3:48

Speaker 1

All of my, my, me personally or like.

3:51

Speaker 3

Have broken some laws on the Internet on some **** sites displaying some sort of ****.

We have been detected some issues and we have been detected that where you are, where your devices are, we will be demolishing all your social identity and leaking them on the **** site itself.

4:08

Speaker 1

You're going just, I want to be perfectly, I want to be perfectly clear here.

You're saying that you are going to first of all destroy all of my social media stuff, then you're going to leak it onto a porn site?

4:23

Speaker 3

That's fine.

4:24

Speaker 1

Cool, I'm recording this.

I hope that you like being on YouTube because this is definitely going to go on there.

4:33

Speaker 3

Ah, Seriously tell me the channel where what game you will upload it?

4:38

Speaker 1

OK, So what?

So in all honesty, like what is your?

What is the deal?

You.

4:42

Speaker 3

You tell me, you tell me.

What's the channel name?

What's the channel name?

I'll subscribe you.

I will like you I will share I will do everything.

4:48

Speaker 1

Cool.

What's the scam you guys are running?

What do you What do you do when you call people?

What are you trying to get from them?

Do you sell them Antivirus software?

Is that the deal?

4:58

Speaker 3

Oh yeah, yeah, yeah, that's what we do.

5:00

Speaker 1

And how much are you selling it for?

5:01

Speaker 3

$400.

5:03

Speaker 1

Really 400?

5:05

Speaker 3

Yeah, yeah.

5:07

Speaker 1

And how and like how, how many sales would you say you make in a day?

5:12

Speaker 3

Here are here we are around 50 to 55 people and we make around I, I personally make around six or seven sales a day.

5:21

Speaker 1

So 6 or 7 sales a day.

So that's what is like 7, four.

I'm really bad at math.

I'm sorry.

That's like $2800 a day.

Somewhat.

Wow.

How much of that do you get to keep?

Speaker 3

50%

Speaker 1

50%

5:36

Speaker 3

Yeah.

Don't you feel bad at all about scamming people who don't know anything about computers?

5:42

Speaker 3

No, I don't.

5:43

Speaker 1

Why not?

5:46

Speaker 3

Why would I?

5:48

Speaker 1

Because.

5:48

Speaker 3

You guys have a lot of money.

That's reason we spent.

5:51

Speaker 1

Who?

Who is you guys?

Who are you talking about?

5:55

Speaker 3

Like the people we scam?

5:57

Speaker 1

But how do you know how much money I have?

6:01

Speaker 3

We judge them like we make a judgement, like somebody with the name Richard or having a very good name.

We say, like they all, they must be having a good amount of money.

6:10

Speaker 1

Wait people, the amount of money someone has isn't based on what their name is!

6:16

Speaker 3

Oh yes.

6:50

Speaker 1

Let me How did you choose me?

How did you find so this guy who says his name's Alex Martin?

We talked for a couple more minutes.

I asked him stuff like how did you get my number?

And he won't answer me.

And then he hangs up.

So the second time I called back, I did not get Alex Martin.

7:00

Sadly, I got a different guy.

7:08

Speaker 3

So this site Charlie, and I'm a certified technician who support Apple customers.

7:10

Speaker 1

Nice to meet you, Charlie.

7:13

Speaker 3

So I checked your number Sir, and it says that your Apple ID has been compromised.

7:18

Speaker 1

What does that mean?

And rather than say right away I know this is a scam, I let him diagnose my computer.

I let him connect to my computer.

7:29

Speaker 2

Really?!

7:30

Speaker 1

Yes.

7:31

Speaker 3

On the top of the browser in the address bar, type a technical website that is WWW dot.

7:38

Speaker 2

That is bad judgment.

Like you gave him remote access.

7:42

Speaker 1

Yes.

7:43

Speaker 3

So we are successfully connected now.

Sir, can you see my cursor moving on your screen?

7:47

Speaker 1

Yes, I can.

7:48

Speaker 2

So what did he do when he started to get in there?

7:51

Speaker 1

Oh My God it is the best.

I could not believe how amazing it was.

Speaker 2

What?

Speaker 1

OK

Speaker 2

so weird.

Speaker 1

So what this guy did is he got on my computer, he opened up the terminal, which is just this little window that allows you to enter text commands into your computer.

8:07

Speaker 2

I've been in there like twice.

When you open Terminal, it looks like you're hacking a mainframe in a bad movie.

8:13

Speaker 1

Right, that's exactly what it looks like.

And he ran a command called netstat.

And what netstat does is throw up a bunch of information about your computer, like connections to the Internet.

It has the old school hacker look that you're talking about.

Yeah.

So then he suddenly makes the terminal window incredibly small.

8:35

Speaker 2

Like he just made it like postage Sam size.

8:37

Speaker 1

Yes, so that he could still use it, but I couldn't see what he was doing.

Why did it get so small?

Don't.

8:43

Speaker 3

Give me one second Sir, trying.

8:44

Speaker 1

To read it.

8:46

Speaker 3

Even I don't know, Sir.

Just give me one second, Sir.

8:49

Speaker 2

That is so like.

9:04

Speaker 1

And then he made it big again and written in it was something like iCloud compromised SSED hacked.

And then it said it.

9:09

What it meant to say was Zeus Trojan detected.

But what he had, what he had typed, was Zeus troan detected, with no J.

What's Zeus troan?

9:20

Speaker 3

OK, the warning Zeus.

Trojan, Sir.

9:24

Speaker 1

But it doesn't say.

9:25

Speaker 3

Trojan is found in your device.

9:27

Speaker 1

It says Troan, it doesn't say Trojan.

9:31

Speaker 3

It doesn't say Trojan.

9:33

Speaker 1

No, it says Troan.

There's no J.

9:34

Speaker 3

Yes, wow.

9:39

Speaker 1

And then without missing a beat, he continues to to like, go through his script and he says.

9:45

Speaker 3

OK, it says that your Apple ID is compromised and it's used.

Troan is found OK.

9:54

Speaker 2

He's a good improv comedian.

9:57

Speaker 1

So at that point, I, I revealed again that I knew who what was going on.

Charlie, I know that I know, I know that you're scamming me.

I know that you're at least trying to scam me because I know what net.

Speaker 3

Yes I know

Speaker 1

I know.

What netstat does.

10:10

Speaker 3

Yes, exactly, Sir.

You're a genius, Sir.

You're intelligent.

10:14

Speaker 1

I'm not that intelligent.

10:15

Speaker 3

Yes, Sir, you're technically savvy.

10:18

Speaker 1

I'm not that technically savvy, I just know that you misspelled Trojan.

10:22

Speaker 3

But you are a little bit.

10:23

Speaker 1

So I'm curious, are you really?

I tried to get this guy to tell me more about what was going on at this call center, but he pretty quickly hung up on me.

They have.

10:31

Speaker 2

Like a picture of you in the call center.

So.

10:34

Speaker 1

That's like, do not surf this man.

Yeah.

So I keep calling them back.

And eventually I realized that the mistake that I'm making is that I am so excited to let these guys know that I'm on to them, that I don't let them play out their entire script.

10:48

Uncovering Accostings Infotech's Exploitative Tech Support Scam

So I don't know what the full scam actually is, so I call back again.

10:54

Speaker 3

How can I help you?

10:55

Speaker 1

And I get Alex, the guy from the first call, but I don't want him to know that it's me, so he's a different name.

I tell him my name is Rusty Savage and we go through the entire thing again.

11:05

Speaker 3

All right, Sir.

So now we are connected, Sir.

11:07

Speaker 1

He opens up the terminal, he runs netstat, says I have a virus, and then I say like, oh, that sounds terrible, what do I do to fix it?

11:17

Speaker 3

So to fix this kind of problem, we will acquire some other also network technicians of Level 9 and they must be certified from Apple to handle this case.

11:30

Speaker 1

So he forwards me to the technician level 9 and that technician tells me to go to a website called Quick PC Resolve.

11:39

Speaker 2

Quick PC Resolve!

11:40

Speaker 1

Do you want to take a look at quickpcresolve.com?

11:43

Speaker 2

Yeah, hold on.

See like I feel trepidation about visiting this website.

11:49

Speaker 1

You shouldn't.

11:51

Speaker 2

Well, that's what you say.

OK, so I'm I'm I'm at quick PC Resolve.

OK, so so it's a lot of stock photos.

12:08

There's a really happy businesswoman with her with her arms in a victory pose.

Next generation tech support, we assure you best experience with us.

There are a lot of copywriting and and graphic design choices that suggest like this certainly isn't Apple like it like it looks.

It doesn't look great.

12:25

Speaker 1

Right.

So we got to this website and the level 9 technician was like, OK, so I'm going to need your credit card.

This is going to cost a couple $100.

And I was like, OK, listen, I am not going to give you my credit card information because I know this is a scam.

12:42

Like, how stupid do you think that I am?

Do you just have a really low opinion of Americans in general?

Speaker 3

Yes.

Speaker 1

And why do you have a low opinion of them?

12:51

Speaker 3

You guys are conservative mind of people till you are fighting for who is black and who is white.

Everyone is human being, but you guys are doing terrible thing to your brother, your people, they are living in your country and you are killing them and you are robbing them and you are saying that you are very honest.

13:09

Speaker 1

I'm going to be honest with you.

I agree with you.

But listen, I am a human being.

13:15

Speaker 3

You are also human being when you bomb 194745 atom bomb on Japan.

Have you heard about that?

13:24

Speaker 1

I have heard about that.

13:25

Speaker 3

Millions of millions, millions and millions of people died.

13:29

Speaker 1

And I was in.

13:30

Speaker 3

Japan Babies Babies are born in paralyzed and disabled.

13:35

Speaker 1

That was 45 years before I was born, so I only had so much decision making power when that happened.

13:41

Speaker 3

So listen to me, you are all that.

Where was the humanity of those American people that point of time?

All right, you're talking about human being.

What?

You don't have answer of my question and you are giving me thought.

You are giving me long speech about the human being I have.

13:58

What do you what?

Just don't talk.

14:00

Speaker 1

I'm not a.

You can hang up the phone.

14:01

Speaker 3

Phone.

No, no, you do.

It doesn't to me.

14:03

Speaker 1

But it was a long and very frustrating conversation and eventually he got tired of me and hung up just like they always do.

And I would say under 5 minutes later I was getting ready to leave the studio and the phone, the studio phone rang.

14:21

Hello.

14:23

Speaker 3

Yeah, Hi.

Is that Alex Goldman?

14:24

Speaker 1

Hey, what's up?

It was Alex Martin again.

14:26

Speaker 3

Yeah.

Hi, Alex.

How are you?

Good.

You're a liar.

14:30

Speaker 1

What do you mean?

14:33

Speaker 3

Why?

You said your name is Rusty Savage?

My name is Alex.

I know, but.

14:37

Speaker 1

So how's it going, Alex?

14:41

Speaker 3

How's it going?

Great, buddy.

Great.

You, you fool me.

You got me, you know, And it's so embarrassing, buddy.

14:47

Speaker 1

I appreciate you calling me back man.

14:50

Speaker 3

Yeah, I did.

I I I want to talk to a person who fooled me.

My goodness.

I don't know how I felt for you.

14:58

Speaker 1

So the guy who I was talking to was really indignant and super mad.

Is he actually a third party company or is he just part of the same company you're at?

15:06

Speaker 3

He wasn't a third party company.

He's he's just a third person sitting next to me.

15:11

Speaker 1

Of course.

Oh man.

15:16

Speaker 3

You're a famous personality on Google, you know, So you just Google your name and you got to silly looking guy having a half bald hairs, bit fat and wedding spectacles having a weird smile.

15:26

Speaker 1

Oh yeah, I do have.

15:27

Speaker 3

A gay.

15:28

Speaker 1

I do have a weird smile.

I don't know.

I mean, I'm.

15:30

Speaker 3

Yeah, you have a very weird smile.

15:32

Speaker 1

It's kind of me like.

15:33

Speaker 3

Come and kiss me right away.

15:35

Speaker 1

I don't want to kiss you, but I.

15:37

Speaker 3

Of course, thank God, thank God, thank God you don't want to.

15:42

Speaker 1

What do you do for fun?

15:44

Speaker 3

I'm a hacker, whatever, stuff like piss me off, I hack it.

15:48

Speaker 1

So are you going to hack me?

15:51

Speaker 3

Well, when I'll be doing that, you never pissed me.

15:54

Speaker 1

Oh well that's good.

I was worried that I might have made you mad.

I mean you did call me fat 2 minutes ago.

15:59

Speaker 3

I know buddy, I was just for.

I was just kidding.

16:02

Speaker 1

OK, cool, cool, cool, cool.

That means a lot to me.

16:04

Speaker 3

Yeah, what do you, what do you do?

What do you do?

Like you, What do you do for fun?

16:08

Speaker 1

Play guitar, play video games.

16:13

Speaker 3

What games you play?

16:16

Speaker 1

Well, you know, here's the problem.

I have an old computer.

You, you, you know, you've, you guys have been on it plenty of times and it I play, I play a lot on, on Steam, but I mostly play like older games like Team Fortress 2.

16:31

I like a lot stuff like that.

What do you play?

16:36

Speaker 3

What do I play counter strike Warcraft?

16:40

Speaker 1

Are you good at Counter Strike?

16:43

Speaker 3

Pretty good.

How hell.

Good.

16:45

Speaker 1

I suck at that game.

I suck at that game.

16:47

Speaker 3

You suck it, come.

16:49

Speaker 1

On I don't know, I like.

I like.

16:51

Speaker 3

What do you what do you really mind if I call you back now?

Right away?

I'll give you a quick call back.

What do you mind?

16:58

Speaker 1

Why he didn't call back?

17:04

Speaker 2

How old do you think this person was?

That is like the homophobia of a junior high schooler or a high schooler.

17:09

Speaker 1

He told me he was 22.

17:12

Speaker 3

Huh.

17:13

Speaker 1

He's a kid, and I kept calling the call center back asking for Alex, but I couldn't get him again.

It was like he totally vanished.

By this point, everyone at the call center was just stonewalling me.

Like they were totally done with me, but I was not done with them.

17:34

I was determined to figure these guys out, and I had a piece of evidence to go on that website.

Quick PC Resolve.

18:03

Welcome back to the show.

So, PJ, this story has like ballooned in terms of its complexity and density.

And so I have, since the beginning, basically been working with producer Damiano Marchetti on research.

He is in the studio right now.

18:16

Speaker 2

Hi, PJ, Hey, Damiano.

18:18

Speaker 1

So you'll remember that before the break we have one piece of evidence to go on, which is this website Quick PC Resolve.

We looked up The Who is record for Quick PC Resolve and we found a couple of names associated with it.

And when we checked to see if those people had any other websites, we found this whole great constellation of scammy tech support websites that looked exactly like Quick PC Resolve.

18:39

Got it.

But there's one website that was associated with these guys that was different.

18:44

Speaker 2

Which was it?

Was this website calledaccostings.com accostings like to accost someone?

18:51

Speaker 1

It's a weird name for a website, even weirder name for a company.

The company is called Accostings Infotech Private Limited.

19:00

Speaker 2

OK.

And when we go and look at the website, it's so different than the other ones we've seen.

It says very clearly that it's a call center and has what looks like a real address on Club Rd. in New Delhi, has a real Indian phone number.

19:15

Speaker 1

Not a 1800 number like all the other ones have.

19:18

Speaker 2

And so we're like, is this like the parent company?

Like is this the place where all of these scams are coming from?

19:30

Speaker 3

Hello.

19:31

Speaker 1

So in order to figure that out I just called the number on the Acostings website.

Hi I'm trying to reach Technical Support.

19:38

Speaker 3

Yep.

How can I help you Sir?

19:42

Speaker 1

Just to be clear, this is quick PC resolve.

19:45

Speaker 3

Yes, yes, it's a quick PC result Sir.

Absolutely correct.

19:49

Speaker 1

Thank you very much.

And so then I went to all the other websites.

I called all the other 1800 numbers and asked them if they were Quick PC Resolve and they all said yes.

It doesn't matter which one of these websites we go to, it doesn't matter which number we call.

They're all going to the same call center.

20:04

It's the same company.

It's this company Accostings.

And so we started researching Accostings and there was this one name that kept popping up over and over again, this name Kamal Verma.

And I was like, who is this guy?

So I just started calling the call center and asking for him.

20:23

Speaker 3

Thank you for calling Premium Technical Support.

How may I help you?

20:27

Speaker 1

Yeah, I'm trying to reach Kamal Verma.

My name is Alex Goldman.

I call you guys pretty regularly.

Is he there?

20:40

Speaker 3

Hello.

20:41

Speaker 1

Yeah, trying to reach Kamal Verma.

20:45

Speaker 3

Please stop calling us.

20:47

Speaker 1

I'm not going to until I sort of get the answers that I'm interested.

20:51

Speaker 3

In OK, then keep calling us.

Keep calling us.

You know what you are an asshole.

21:01

Speaker 1

Why?

21:01

Speaker 3

You are.

You are an asshole.

You're an asshole.

21:04

Speaker 1

Why would you say that?

21:06

Speaker 3

Because you are an asshole.

But why?

You don't know about it.

You're bothering.

Who is Who is?

Come, come on.

Where, Master?

I don't know.

21:17

Speaker 1

Can you put me in touch with him?

21:20

Speaker 3

Do one thing, just bear with me.

Bear with me for one minute.

21:42

Hello.

21:42

Speaker 1

Hi.

21:44

Speaker 3

Yeah, this is the wrong number, Sir.

21:46

Speaker 1

No it isn't.

I know it's not the wrong number.

21:48

Speaker 3

Yeah, I'm going for a dinner.

Bye bye.

21:54

Speaker 1

So I didn't really get anywhere, but on that last call, you can hear a couple people speaking in Hindi faintly in the background.

So I got Shruti Ravindran, who is a producer on another Gimlet show, Science Versus and also speaks Hindi, to come into the studio and listen to see if she could translate for me.

22:12

Speaker 2

Devious.

22:13

Speaker 3

I think so.

The person said he keeps calling and he's taking, this is a Hindiism taking Kamal sir's name.

I mean he professed to not know this guy, but he used like a respectful term to call him.

22:31

So he does recognize him.

And then I think he was proposing by the end.

The other person that he spoke to was proposing by the end to say it was the wrong number.

22:42

Speaker 1

So Shruti told us that these guys are using a term of respect for Kamal, like a term that you would use for a superior.

And so we're pretty sure that Kamal is the boss of accostings.

And Damiano starts to dig really deep on this guy.

22:55

Speaker 2

Yeah, I started doing tons of research on him.

I find his Facebook page, which of course has all these pictures on it, and I want to show you one of them.

So Kamal.

And like all the big wigs, I think they like to go to this bar called Chug It.

Chug It.

23:08

Speaker 1

Down the street from from the office, Kamal is the second from the left.

23:15

Speaker 2

Oh, he looks like the boss.

23:17

Speaker 1

Yeah, he looks like a tough guy, right?

23:19

Speaker 2

He, I mean, he's just like he's got like everybody, everybody who's not him is like a little bit like Schlumpier.

Like, I don't know, he's got like a very Salani haircut and like his clothes are a little bit more fashionable.

23:35

He's yeah, he just looks like the boss.

23:37

Speaker 1

Totally.

23:38

Speaker 2

So for weeks Alex was calling the call center and asking for Kamal in the meantime, like I was dying to know more about this call center costings.

23:49

Speaker 3

Hello.

Hello.

Yeah.

Hi, Damiana.

23:51

Speaker 2

Hi, how are you?

I started to find former employees who listed a costings on their LinkedIn or their Facebook.

23:57

Speaker 3

Yeah, so is this.

23:58

Speaker 2

Almost everyone we interviewed said I'll talk, but please don't use my name.

When was it that you worked there?

24:05

Speaker 3

I worked there for two years of working as a salesperson between 2009 to 2011.

24:13

Speaker 2

So this guy explained to me that when Alex and I are calling her costings, most of the people that we're talking to are super young, like this is probably their first job.

24:21

Speaker 3

Most of them are students who belongs to eastern northeastern part of India like Manipuri and all.

They have a bit sound knowledge of English like at if compared with any other part of India like their accent is quite understandable.

24:41

I guess so.

24:42

Speaker 2

Is it like a poorer part of India too?

And that's so it's easier to recruit people.

24:46

Speaker 3

Yes, yes it is.

24:48

Speaker 2

So what happens is like these kids, they come from these like small rural towns.

A lot of the time they get to the big city and they get what they think is just like a normal, honest job.

24:58

Speaker 3

When I was hired with them, they told me they have a legitimate process with them.

25:02

Speaker 1

So when you started, they said we have a legitimate process with Apple.

25:07

Speaker 3

That's right.

But sooner and later I got to know that this was something, you know, fishy going on.

25:13

Speaker 1

Did anybody that you worked with, was anybody that you worked with open about the fact that they were committing fraud or was everybody, did everybody just pretend like that wasn't happening?

25:22

Speaker 3

You know, there were people who know that this is not good happening, but it's just that there was no other option to, you know, survive.

They have to do it because if they if they will not do it, then they have to go back to their hometown and stay there.

And there is no job there.

25:40

I'll tell you the I'll tell you the main reason.

I mean, the reason why I left that company because there was a fight for they were like delaying my salary again and again.

25:49

Speaker 1

Really.

They weren't paying you.

25:52

Speaker 3

Yeah, this is how I mean, it's not with me.

It's like they were doing with everybody.

The same thing happened with me as well.

I did not receive my money when I asked.

I asked them that they owe my money and they need to pay me, but they completely said no, that they cannot pay.

26:12

Man, I can give you all this information, but make sure you don't, you know, disclose my name because you know they would be after me if they get to know that, you know, I gave you all this information.

26:23

Speaker 1

OK, I can keep you anonymous.

26:24

Speaker 3

What I realized later on, you know, when I was there in the company for two months, you know, I realized because these guys are earning good amount of money, OK?

So you know they can do anything to you in terms of if you go against them or if you tell them, but this is what is going on.

26:40

You know they can really do something harmful against you.

26:44

Speaker 1

What do you mean what what what kind of threats did they they give you?

26:48

Speaker 3

If they get to know, you know, you know that I have given you my information.

They have my resume, my home address with them and everything.

They have my phone number and everything.

So, you know, they might, you know, send cops to my place and tell them that I have, you know, stolen their data or their company information and all that stuff.

27:07

Speaker 1

I see.

So accosting seems like a pretty precarious place to work.

People told us that turnover, they're super high.

People are quitting or getting fired all the time, which explains something that I've been wondering about for a while, which was Alex Martin, the first guy that we talked to, he had just completely vanished and it seemed likely to me that he probably quit or got fired and.

27:32

Speaker 2

We learned something else really interesting, which is that accosting it didn't start out this way.

Like it didn't always.

It wasn't always so sketchy.

They actually started the company as like a real tech support company and they were helping people with their problems.

And then like a couple years in, it seems like what happened is that they were like, you know, what would be a better way of getting business?

27:51

Instead of calling people, like cold calling people and saying, hey, maybe you'll get a virus sometime in the future, say you have a virus right now.

Exactly.

And pay us $300 once you pay us to get rid of the virus that you supposedly have on your computer.

We'll also support you in the future and be your tech support company.

28:07

So they're lying, but they're still selling a real product.

They're lying.

Exactly.

Just a way of drumming up business.

You go from being like the local security guard company to being the guy who's like, it'd be a shame if anything happened here.

Exactly.

28:18

Speaker 1

And, you know, the whole time we thought about this company as being very remote from us, like a bunch of people in a room trying to scam us thousands of miles away.

But we talked to someone who used to work there who made us realize that their reach extends across the globe.

28:34

Speaker 3

So what they told me that they were taking payments through check in USI know the name of the company on which they were taking the checks as well.

The name of the company is MSS Marketing LLC and it's in Pennsylvania.

28:53

Speaker 1

I called the woman who runs it and she said yes, I used to take payments for a costings.

But she claims that she shut MSS marketing down months ago.

29:01

Speaker 2

Interesting.

So every time someone gets scammed on the phone by someone in another country or not.

Maybe not every time, but basically if somebody tricks you on the phone and and takes your credit card or whatever, they need to have a confederate who's actually based in the country that you're in.

29:15

Speaker 1

Exactly, and this isn't just happening in the US.

We found these guys who live in Bradford, England who are setting up websites and companies so that they can process money for our costings in the UK and it seems like our costings is making a ton of money.

29:34

We don't know exactly how much, but based on what a former employee told me, probably in the realm of about $2,000,000 a year.

And the people who are taking my calls, they're being like intimidated by this company.

They're not making a lot of money.

They're being treated like crap.

But someone like Kamal is probably cleaning up.

29:53

Speaker 2

So it's like basically like every piece of information you learn just makes Kamal like more and more of a cartoon villain character basically, right?

Like he is the big bad guy at this point.

30:03

Kamal Quits, Invites Alex to India

Exactly, which is why it was so frustrating that we couldn't get him on the phone no matter how hard we tried.

And then executive producer Tim Howard came up with a crazy idea.

30:15

Speaker 2

Can I tell you what my crazy idea would be?

What to call and just say this is Kamal.

30:19

Speaker 1

Hi, this is Kamal.

Do I have any messages from Alex Goldman?

Yeah.

30:25

Speaker 2

Was that Tim's idea?

No, what was Tim's crazy idea?

30:28

Speaker 1

Tim was like, you need to throw these guys off balance a little bit, like you're just being too straightforward.

They know what to expect from you.

They can just hang up on you.

Yeah, why don't you take one of the photos you found of them on Facebook, make it your desktop background, and then have them connect to your computer?

30:45

Speaker 2

That's so creepy.

That's.

30:47

Speaker 1

Great.

It's nuts.

30:48

Speaker 2

Wait, so do you remember that?

Yeah.

So, so when they call, they like remote in and they do like the fake, like you have Berg's thing or whatever.

You've got a Trogan horse, and so your plan is like when they remote into your computer, they're just going to see like a smiling picture of themselves hanging out.

31:05

Speaker 1

Yeah, but not just a smiling picture of themselves.

It's a smiling picture of like their bosses.

31:09

Speaker 2

So this is a very, very funny plan.

So what happened?

31:14

Speaker 1

So I call up and some guy I don't recognize answers and we just start going through the routine where he gets on my computer, you know?

31:22

Speaker 3

Your Mac computer is going to connect to our secure server and after that we are going to run a diagnosis on that.

31:29

Speaker 1

OK, the a little box showed up in the lower right hand corner, it says.

31:33

Speaker 3

Yeah, please join session click on.

31:37

Speaker 1

OK, connect, here I go.

31:39

Speaker 3

Yeah.

Yes, Sir.

31:42

Speaker 1

And then I minimize everything on my screen, leaving only the picture on the desktop.

31:47

Speaker 3

Now we are well connected.

OK, wait a second.

Is he still on your computer?

32:04

Speaker 1

I think he hung up.

Hello.

Hello.

32:10

Speaker 3

Be online Sir.

Be online name Alex Map Oh my.

32:20

Speaker 2

God, Oh my God.

Oh my God.

What's he doing on your computer?

32:29

Speaker 3

Be online, be online.

32:31

Speaker 2

What's he doing?

My heart is beating so fast.

32:49

Speaker 3

Yeah.

Thank you so much for being online, Sir.

This side Alexander Martin, how are you doing today?

32:53

Speaker 1

Hey, Alex Martin, how's it going?

32:56

Speaker 3

I'm doing great, Sir.

How are you?

32:58

Speaker 1

I'm good.

What's up?

33:00

Speaker 3

I'm doing great, thanks a lot for asking.

How's your day going, Sir?

33:03

Speaker 1

Pretty good.

Thanks.

33:05

Speaker 3

That's good.

That's wonderful.

33:08

Speaker 1

Is this the Alex Martin that I talked to a while back?

This is Alex Goldman.

33:13

Speaker 3

Yeah, that's not the same Alex Martin.

So you Remember Me?

33:16

Speaker 1

How's it going man?

I've been trying to get in touch with you for weeks.

33:19

Speaker 3

My goodness, I was out for a week and I was in Thailand on my vacations.

33:23

Speaker 1

What have you been up to?

Did you?

What do you think of my desktop background?

33:27

Speaker 3

Oh, who are they?

I don't recognize them.

Who are they?

33:30

Speaker 1

Give me a break.

Come on man, I know better than that.

33:34

Speaker 3

Seriously, I like are you one of them?

Who are you?

33:38

Speaker 1

So Alex, dude, I've been trying to get in touch with you, man.

I've been learning a lot about quick PC Resolve and costings info tech and sort of like people who work there, people who used to work there.

But I was worried that you might have gotten canned or something.

33:54

It's glad.

I'm glad to hear your voice.

33:58

Speaker 3

So what exactly you want now?

34:00

Speaker 1

Well, I just wanted to know how you were doing first of all, second of all.

34:05

Speaker 3

Yeah, I'm very good.

34:06

Speaker 1

Second of all, what about yourself?

Well, the reason I was trying to reach you is because I wanted, I wanted to see if you, you said you played Counter Strike and you and I was wondering if you were on Steam, because if you're on Steam, I could give you my Steam ID.

We could play some games together.

34:20

Speaker 3

No need.

You don't have any work to do or what?

34:23

Speaker 1

Up until this point, Alex Martin has always been like, interested in me.

He wants to talk about video games and stuff.

And all of a sudden, in this moment, he becomes really hostile.

And honestly, it kind of threw me off balance a little bit.

Like, I didn't know how to proceed.

34:38

This is my work.

But I mean, you know, when you're not at work, you said you like to play video games.

I was wondering if you want to play some games together?

34:45

Speaker 3

What game you like?

34:47

Speaker 1

Well, let's see, what do I?

Let me just let me just bring up my steam and see what I've got going on there.

You seem angry with me.

Are you mad at me?

34:56

Speaker 3

Me.

Yeah.

No, I'm not angry at all.

I'm very calm, you know, Very calm, very cool.

35:01

Speaker 1

All right, what have I got here?

The only.

35:04

Speaker 3

Thing is that I want to find out what exactly you want.

That's what I want to know.

35:10

Speaker 1

So I've got I've got Team Fortress 2 Counter Strike.

You're.

35:15

Speaker 3

Not coming to the point.

You know what I'm asking you.

I'm asking you what exactly you want.

35:20

Speaker 1

Well, so I got a call from this number a while back and.

35:25

Speaker 3

That was ages before.

Yeah, that was ages before.

35:28

Speaker 1

And the the purpose of that call was to try and try and scam me out of money.

35:34

Speaker 3

But you were not scammed, fortunately, yeah.

35:35

Speaker 1

Yeah, but I know that a lot of other people probably are being scammed.

35:40

Speaker 3

So what?

You are a social worker or what?

35:43

Speaker 1

Well, no, I'm a journalist.

35:47

Speaker 3

So I mean you don't have any other companies to find out that are they doing scam or not?

35:52

Speaker 1

Well, no other companies called me man.

35:55

Speaker 3

I'll give you some names here.

OK, write it down.

35:58

Speaker 1

Of other companies.

36:00

Speaker 3

Yeah.

36:01

Speaker 1

I mean, I they're.

36:02

Speaker 3

Bigger they, they'll be bigger fishes for you.

OK, instead of coming to me, go for them.

You'll get more money from there because if you come to me, you won't get anything.

So you're wasting your time.

36:12

Speaker 1

So he's saying like, if you come to me, you won't get anything, I'm not giving you any money.

And it's suddenly felt like I was talking to a boss, and then it hit me that I might actually be talking to the boss.

36:28

Like what if Alex Martin is Kamal?

36:32

Speaker 2

Oh, that is nuts.

36:34

Speaker 1

Yeah.

So is this Kamal that I'm talking to?

36:38

Speaker 3

Yeah, this is Kamal.

36:40

Speaker 1

Is it really?

36:42

Speaker 3

So you don't recognize me or what?

36:43

Speaker 1

Well, how am I supposed to?

Every time I call I get a different name.

How am I supposed to know that this is Kamal?

36:49

Speaker 3

Because you know, when they came to know that you are the same guy with whom I have already spoken with.

So they transferred the call to me, you know, and.

36:59

Speaker 1

You know as the conversation went on he started to refer to things that only Kamal would know.

Like a few weeks before he made this call we had our Co worker Shruti try to friend him on Facebook and he brought that up and I was like oh this guy that I'm talking to really is Kamal.

37:16

Speaker 2

That is nuts.

I can't even process that, so the wow.

37:26

Speaker 1

Yeah, I must have gotten the floor manager the first time.

37:33

Speaker 2

Oh my God.

37:34

Speaker 1

Yeah.

37:36

Speaker 2

No wonder he sounds like so at ease with what he's doing, you know what I mean?

37:41

Speaker 1

And Kamal basically said to me, come, Alex.

Kamal said to me like, look, you need to stop calling during business hours and disrupting my texts.

And I was like, what do you want me to do?

And he gave me his number.

37:54

Speaker 2

What he?

37:55

Speaker 1

Gave me his e-mail address.

What?

And was like, call me back when you like, call back my number instead of calling my technicians on the floor.

38:03

Speaker 2

That's so funny.

38:05

Speaker 1

So at this point, it's the end of March.

It's been about two months since the first call and I started just calling Kamal pretty regularly over the next couple weeks.

38:17

Speaker 2

And would he pick up he?

38:18

Speaker 1

Would Hello.

Hey, Kamal.

Kamal, hello.

38:24

Speaker 3

Yes, yes, your voice is breaking.

38:26

Speaker 2

And which Kamal would you get?

Would you get the Kamal that's like jeering at you for being a slovenly American?

Would you get the nice Kamal that talks to you about how you like to play Counter Strike?

38:34

Speaker 1

I got we got sort of like a laid back kind of quiet Kamal.

It was a very different Kamal than I was used to.

He would just sort of answer my questions.

Did you grow up in Delhi?

38:45

Speaker 3

No, not at all.

I belong to Punjab.

I'm not from Delhi.

38:49

Speaker 1

What made you move to Delhi in the first place?

38:52

Speaker 3

Just want to see the Delhi life, that's it.

I just came here with one of the friend and then I thought like let me work here for a few years and I work and then I enjoy it.

39:01

Speaker 1

And I'm honestly not learning that much from Kamal in these conversations.

We're just sort of having idle chitchat.

But at the same time, me and Damiano are researching a costings and it's during this time that we realized that Kamal is not actually the boss.

Kamal is the boss's right hand man.

39:17

So here let me show you this photo.

It's of them in their new office.

39:22

Speaker 2

Oh, there are so many employees at this company now.

That's the whole team.

Yeah.

And the guy at the center, that's the top boss.

It's a guy named Deepak Verma.

So the guy who's wearing, like, traditional garb.

And then I think, like, literally, Kamal is his right hand, man.

39:41

He's he's actually sitting at his right hand.

Yeah.

And so we start to think maybe Kamal gave us his personal phone number because he doesn't want his boss to know that he's talking to us.

39:52

Speaker 1

And I would say a couple weeks after he gave me a cell phone number, he started saying, I think, you know, I think my time at this company is about to near, is about to come to an end.

How you doing?

40:07

Speaker 3

Yeah, not so good these days.

I mean, even, I mean everyone is not switching, you know, no one.

So even I'm thinking of planning, of doing my own thinking that I'll do something for myself, you know, a small setup or something.

40:18

Speaker 1

Wait, wait.

So you wait, you're planning on leaving a costings?

40:23

Speaker 3

Yeah, yeah.

40:24

Speaker 1

And starting your own business.

40:27

Speaker 3

Yeah.

40:28

Speaker 2

When he would say that, did it feel like he wanted to leave the company to go start another scam company or was it like I want to leave?

Maybe I don't want to scam people anymore.

40:39

Speaker 1

It never seemed like he didn't.

He had like a particular moral calm about scamming, but he did did seem like he was kind of burnt out.

Why do you want to leave?

40:49

Speaker 3

It's just like that.

I don't want to work anymore.

That's it.

I just want to go village and stay in village.

You know, my father, they used to call me every other day.

They'd come back, come back.

41:00

Speaker 1

And at first, I wasn't super convinced that he actually wanted to leave.

I think he kind of wanted to throw me off the trail.

But then, you know, I started, I kept calling the call center.

And one day a couple months later.

41:13

Speaker 3

Your call is very important to us.

Please stay on the line and you'll be transferred to the next available agent.

Thank you for calling premium Technical Support.

My name is Eric.

How can I help you today?

41:22

Speaker 1

Yeah.

My name is Alex Goldman.

I'm trying to reach Kamala Verma.

Is he there?

41:26

Speaker 3

Sir, he left the job today.

What do you mean?

I'm so sorry, Sir.

He's not available, Sir.

Actually, he left the job today, Sir.

41:32

Speaker 1

Huh.

So I hung up, and I immediately called Kamal, and he said, yeah, I quit.

I moved back in with my parents on their farm.

And he was like, look, I moved to the city to see what it was like to try living a metropolitan life.

And I decided that it's not for me.

41:48

And what could be better than just hanging out, waking up whenever I want, going to bed whenever I want, and not really having to work?

Kamal said that he'd left a costings on bad terms, which made me think a little differently about something he'd said to me a couple times on the phone.

42:05

Speaker 3

Any any time whenever you come to India LS do call me OK?

42:09

Speaker 1

I might.

42:09

Speaker 2

Come.

42:10

Speaker 3

If you visit New Delhi, yeah, just come, just come for 2-3 days and I'll make you visit places like Taj Mahal, you know, Agra, nice place to see.

42:21

Speaker 1

Six months ago I got a phone call from someone pretending to be Apple computers and just through sheer force of will and I guess a lot of free time, me and Damiano managed to figure out a lot about these people.

And now an ex manager who parted on bad terms is inviting me to India.

42:40

And I asked him, hey now that you don't work there anymore will you tell me everything I want to know?

And he said, yes, please.

42:48

Speaker 3

Teach your seats in an upright position.

42:52

Alex Prepares for India, Teases Part Two

I mean, how could I not go?

43:46

Speaker 2

Reply All is hosted by me, PJ Vogt and Alice Goldman.

The show is produced this week by Shruti Panamaniani via Benin, Damiano Marchetti and Austin Mitchell, our editors.

Tim Howard.

More editorial help this week from Jorge Just production assistance from Serena On we're mixed by Rick Kwan.

44:01

Special thanks this week to Alan Baranov, Courtney Gregoire of the Microsoft Digital Crimes Unit, Adrian Fischer, Will Maxson of the FTC, Aparna Aluri and Paul Frost.

Two things.

If you suspect you may have been a victim of a Technical Support scam, you can file a complaint with the Federal Trade Commission.

44:19

We've included a link in the description of this episode.

Also, if you have time, there is a brief survey that we really benefit from you filling out.

It's at reply all dot club.

It is a mix of questions.

Some of them are to help advertisers.

Some of them are to help us figure out who's listening and what you like about the show.

44:39

Again, that is Reply All. dot club.

Mat Lieber is the best part of the summer.

Reply All is now available on Spotify.

Go check us out there.

You can also listen to the show on Google Play and Apple Podcasts wherever you listen.

Thanks for listening.

We will be back with Part 2 of this story

45:11

The air on this planet is weird.

It doesn't allow for more than one sound to.

45:20

Speaker 3

Travel at any time, so there's never any.

So there's never any overlap.

There are all these instruments

45:40

Speaker 2

never

hear 2 at once.

46:21

Speaker 3

continuity.

Never mind.